
Religion

An Open-Source Summary

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Class summaries are handwritten and some are notebooklm generated.

1 Class - 2

1.1 Jensen 2014

Jeppe Sinding Jensen's work explores the academic conceptualization of religion, emphasizing that **“religion” is not a “given” objective fact, but rather an analytical term** constructed by scholars to categorize, investigate, and interpret human behavior. Because the borders of what constitutes a religion are fuzzy, Jensen advocates for a **polythetic definition**, meaning religions are grouped by a “family resemblance” of shared elements (like rituals, ideas about the sacred, or ethics) rather than a single, universal characteristic.

To demonstrate how the study of religion is inherently theory-dependent, Jensen outlines **five influential definitions** that represent major intellectual “turns” in the field:

- **Émile Durkheim (Sociological):** Views religion as a unified system of beliefs and practices focused on sacred things, which functions to unite individuals into a single moral community.
- **Sigmund Freud (Psychoanalytic):** Takes a highly critical stance, defining religion as an illusion and a “universal obsessional neurosis” stemming from immature psychological processes and a longing for a father figure.
- **Paul Tillich (Theological/Existential):** Focuses on faith as an “ultimate concern” that provides deep cognitive and emotional meaning, helping humans cope with the existential conditions of their lives.
- **Clifford Geertz (Cultural/Anthropological):** Defines religion as a cultural system of symbols that establish pervasive moods, motivations, and conceptions of the world, making them seem uniquely realistic.
- **Pascal Boyer (Cognitive/Evolutionary):** Argues that religion is an evolutionary by-product (a “spandrel”) that arises from the human brain's natural propensity to pay attention to counter-intuitive representations, such as invisible agents or gods.

Beyond these definitions, Jensen traces the **history of how religion has been studied** and critiqued, which is deeply tied to the rise of Western modernity:

- **The Enlightenment and Reason:** Thinkers like David Hume and John Locke shifted the focus toward naturalistic explanations of religion, doubting scriptural miracles, and advocating for the separation of religion from politics. Deists sought to retain a rationalized, moral version of religion compatible with the laws of nature.
- **Romanticism vs. Positivism:** In contrast to Enlightenment rationality, Romantics like Friedrich Schleiermacher defined religion by individual intuition, emotion, and a feeling of “absolute dependence”. Conversely, positivists like Auguste Comte argued that human intellect would outgrow theology and be replaced entirely by scientific, “positive” knowledge.
- **Radical Critiques:** In the 19th century, Feuerbach labeled religion as a psychological projection, Karl Marx viewed it as the “opium of the people” functioning as a sedative for societal oppression, and Friedrich Nietzsche attacked it as a fraudulent system used to exercise power.

Finally, Jensen breaks down how **different academic disciplines approach religion today**:

- **Intellectualism and History:** Early anthropologists like Edward Burnett Tylor and James George Frazer viewed religion as an early, flawed attempt by humans to explain the cosmos and manipulate nature. Meanwhile, the “history of religions” emerged by applying rigorous, secular historical and philological methods to sacred texts rather than treating them as divine revelation.

- **Individual vs. Collective:** The study of religion split into investigating the **individual** experience through the psychology of religion (figures like William James and Carl Jung) and the **collective** experience through sociology and anthropology, treating religion as structured systems and “social facts” similar to language.
- **Evolutionary Science:** Modern debates weigh whether religion is merely an accidental, non-adaptive outcome of how the human brain evolved (cognitive science), or if it provided an evolutionary advantage by promoting morality, group cohesion, and survival (evolutionary biology and moral psychology).

1.2 Martin 2017

Craig Martin argues that the concept of “religion” cannot be neutrally or objectively defined because its definition is inherently political, socially constructed, and tied to specific human interests. Rather than asking “What is religion?”, Martin suggests we should ask, “Whose interests are being served by this definition?”

To illustrate this, Martin compares defining religion to defining “wetlands” or “yoga”. For example, in Missouri, yoga enthusiasts successfully argued that yoga *was* a religion to avoid state taxes. However, in California, yoga advocates argued it *was not* a religion so it could be taught in public schools without violating the separation of church and state. In both cases, the definition was manipulated to serve a specific agenda.

Martin traces the problematic history of how “religion” has been defined over time:

- **Pre-modern Anachronisms:** Prior to the Protestant Reformation, there was no concept of a “religious” sphere separated from politics and everyday life. Translating ancient words (like the Latin *religio* or Arabic *din*) as “religion” is anachronistic, as these terms meant “custom,” “law,” or “reverence,” not a private institution.
- **A “Useful Fiction” for Peace:** The modern idea of religion as a private, spiritual matter separate from the state was invented by figures like Martin Luther and John Locke. This jurisdictional split was a “useful lie” designed to stop the violent wars between Catholics and Protestants and establish political tolerance, even though churches continued to be highly involved in politics.
- **Colonialism and Chauvinism:** In the 18th and 19th centuries, Europeans used definitions of religion to rank cultures on an evolutionary scale, placing Christianity at the top. Labeling other cultures as having “primitive” or “backward” religions was used to justify imperialism, colonization, and slavery.
- **Christian Privilege:** Even modern scholars who attempt to be neutral often use Protestant Christianity as the “ideal type,” expecting all religions to have a founder, sacred texts, doctrines, and rituals. This bias has historically disenfranchised groups like Native Americans, who initially lacked religious freedom protections because their practices didn’t look enough like Christianity to be legally recognized as a “religion”.
- **The Myth of Irrationality:** Today, religion is often defined as inherently “irrational” in contrast to “rational” science or the secular state. Martin points out the hypocrisy in this, noting that violence committed by groups labeled “religious” (like Al Qaeda) is quickly condemned as irrational, while massive civilian casualties caused by secular nation-states are often justified as rational or necessary.

Ultimately, Martin argues that **finding a perfect, universal definition of religion is impossible**. Colloquial usage lumps together completely dissimilar things simply because of historical habit. If we try to define religion by a lowest common denominator—such as a “belief system,” a focus on the “supernatural,” or a search for the “meaning of life”—the definition inevitably includes things not typically considered religions (like Marxism, American nationalism, or even a Metallica fan club) or excludes traditions we normally count as religions (like atheistic forms of Buddhism).

Because “religion” carries so much historical and normative baggage, and because “religious” cultures function in the exact same ways as “non-religious” cultures, Martin concludes that it is analytically unhelpful to draw fundamental distinctions between the two. For scholars, the study of religion is ultimately just the study of culture.

2 Class - 3

2.1 Fox 2009

Judith Fox's chapter explores the highly contentious debate among sociologists regarding **secularization**, noting that disagreements persist largely due to conflicting definitions and deep ideological assumptions. While early sociologists defined secularization as the declining public significance of religion, the concept is complicated by debates over whether this decline is irreversible, cyclical, or merely a shift from public to private belief.

To explain these divergent views, Fox traces the theoretical roots of the debate back to the Enlightenment's faith in scientific rationality and the foundational theories of Max Weber and Émile Durkheim:

- **Max Weber** argued that the rise of rationalization and modern bureaucracy would lead to the **"disenchantment"** of the world, gradually pushing religion out of public life and into the private sphere.
- **Émile Durkheim**, conversely, believed that religion serves an essential public function by maintaining social cohesion. He argued that while specific religious dogmas might die out, **religion itself would never disappear**; it would simply evolve into new forms and symbols.

Fox then outlines the progression of the **secularization debate** through several key sociological models:

- **The Classic Thesis (Bryan Wilson):** Building on Weber, Wilson argued in the 1960s that modernizing processes inevitably cause religious institutions to lose their social significance. He used statistics to show a decline in religious practice in Britain. While acknowledging that church membership remained high in the United States, Wilson dismissed this as an "acculturated" form of religion where attendance was merely a tool for forging American social identity, rather than deep religious commitment.
- **The 'Religious Economies' Model (Stark and Bainbridge):** Taking a more Durkheimian approach, these scholars argued that human beings have a constant demand for supernatural "compensators" to solve the central problems of existence. They posited that **secularization is self-limiting and cyclical**; as established religions become too rational and secular, they leave a void that is quickly filled by new sects and cults.
- **The 'Rational Choice' Model (Stark and Iannaccone):** This economic model suggests that **religious pluralism acts as a free market** that stimulates religious enthusiasm. Therefore, competitive religious environments like the United States naturally produce high religiosity, whereas places with historically state-sponsored religious monopolies, like Europe, suffer from low religious demand.

Fox highlights that scholars like Sharon Hanson have severely criticized both sides of this debate for talking past one another with incompatible definitions, relying on unverified historical data, and exhibiting a heavily **"christo-centric" bias**—falsely equating the decline of institutional Christianity in the West with the disappearance of religion altogether. Because of these issues, many scholars are now shifting their focus away from secularization and instead studying the diverse landscape of modern **religious pluralism**, noting that people today may be "believing without belonging".

Ultimately, Fox concludes that **secularization theory is practically impossible to test or refute empirically**. Relying on Karl Popper's philosophy of science, she points out that advocates of secularization can always dismiss contrary evidence—such as the rise of new religious movements—as temporary setbacks or mere "superstition". Because the theory's core tenets are so deeply interwoven with the Enlightenment ideals that gave birth to the social sciences, Fox suggests that secularization functions less like a rigorous scientific theory and more like an unfalsifiable ideology.

2.2 Hanson 1997

Expanding on the critique mentioned in Judith Fox's article, Sharon Hanson's 1997 paper argues that the sociological debate surrounding the secularization thesis is deeply flawed because theorists are constantly **"talking at cross purposes"**. She identifies two major reasons for this confusion: a failure to clearly define key terms and a severe lack of rigor in how sociologists use historical data.

To resolve the definitional ambiguity, Hanson suggests dividing secularization arguments into two distinct categories:

- **The Broad Approach:** Focuses on whether religion has lost its social significance at the level of the **social system** (e.g., its influence on politics, legitimation, and power relations).
- **The Narrow Approach:** Focuses on whether religion has lost its significance at the level of **individual consciousness** or personal piety.

Hanson points out that theorists constantly mix these approaches up. For example, a scholar might argue that secularization is happening at a broad, societal level, but then rely almost entirely on church attendance statistics—which are actually evidence for the narrow, individual approach.

Furthermore, Hanson heavily critiques how sociologists "raid" the work of historians without understanding the methodological limits of the data they are using. Much of the secularization debate revolves around comparing modern times to a medieval **"golden age of faith"**. Hanson demonstrates how major scholars misuse historical records to make their points:

- **Stark & Iannaccone's Errors:** To prove their "supply-side" theory that religious participation hasn't declined but merely fluctuates, Stark and Iannaccone attempt to demolish the idea of historical piety. Hanson exposes how they carelessly misused data from historian Peter Laslett regarding the village of Clayworth. They misdated the data to the late 18th century instead of the 17th century, misinterpreted the statistics by failing to account for village demographics (like babies who couldn't take communion), and relied on an outdated edition of the text, completely missing Laslett's later revisions.
- **Steve Bruce's Simplifications:** On the opposing side, Hanson criticizes Steve Bruce for relying too simplistically on quantitative historical statistics. Bruce compares 19th-century church attendance with modern data to prove secularization, but Hanson argues this is an irrelevant comparison because the very nature and definition of "piety" has drastically changed between then and now.

Ultimately, Hanson concludes that unless sociologists establish precise boundaries for their definitions and start applying historical data with much greater care, the secularization thesis will remain a confused, unworkable, and misleading concept.

3 Class - 4

No article

4 Class - 5

4.1 Casanova 2011

In his article, José Casanova proposes a fundamental analytical framework that breaks down the discussion of secularity into three distinct concepts: **"the secular," "secularization," and "secularism"**. By separating these terms, he aims to

better understand modern world-historical processes without reducing them to a single, inevitable path of development.

Here is a summary of the three core concepts explored in the article:

1. The Secular

Casanova traces the concept of “the secular” back to the Latin term *saeculum*, which originally meant an indefinite period of time but evolved in medieval Christendom into a binary system separating the “religious” (monastic life) from the “secular” (the profane world).

- **The Paradox of the Secular:** Originally, the secular was simply what was left over outside of the religious sphere. Paradoxically, in the modern age, the secular has come to be seen as reality *tout court* (the whole of reality)—a natural substratum that remains when religion is removed, rendering religion a “superfluous additive”.
- **Ways of Being Secular:** Casanova outlines three different ways people experience being secular: (a) *mere secularity*, where living without religion is just one normal option among others; (b) *self-sufficient and exclusive secularity*, where living without religion is the taken-for-granted, unquestioned norm; and (c) *secularist secularity*, where individuals feel actively liberated from religion, which they view as essential for human flourishing.

2. Secularizations

“Secularization” generally refers to the historical processes and transformations where “the religious” and “the secular” (such as the state, science, and economy) become differentiated. Casanova argues that the traditional theory of secularization should be disaggregated into three separate subtheses to be properly understood:

- **Institutional differentiation:** The separation of secular spheres from religious institutions.
- **The decline of religion:** The progressive drop in religious beliefs and practices.
- **The privatization of religion:** The confinement of religion to the private sphere. Casanova notes that while Europe experienced all three processes as a single interconnected development, the United States is a prime example of secular differentiation occurring *without* a decline in religion or its strict confinement to the private sphere. Furthermore, he cautions against viewing secularization as a universal global process, emphasizing that it is rooted in Western Christian history and was globalized largely through European colonialism.

3. Secularisms

“Secularism” refers to the modern worldviews, ideologies, and state projects regarding the separation of religion and society. Casanova distinguishes between two primary forms of secularism:

- **Secularism as Statecraft:** This is a political principle of separating state and religion to protect the freedom of conscience for all citizens and ensure equal democratic participation. Political secularism can actually view religion positively as a moral good, so long as it remains in its differentiated sphere.
- **Secularism as Ideology:** This involves progressive philosophies that relegate religion to an irrational, superseded stage of human development that should be banished from the public sphere. Casanova observes a “stadial consciousness” among many Europeans, who view secularism as a sign of modern maturity and religion as inherently backward and “intolerant”. He notes the irony in this view, as it often selectively ignores the massive violence caused by secular ideologies in the 20th century.

Ultimately, Casanova argues that strict secular separation of church and state is not an end in itself, but rather a means to protect the “free exercise” of religion and ensure equal rights within a democracy.

4.2 Shakman Hurd 2008

In *The Politics of Secularism in International Relations*, Elizabeth Shakman Hurd argues that secularism is not merely the natural absence of religion from public life, but is itself a socially constructed form of political authority that profoundly shapes international relations theory and practice. She challenges the common “Westphalian presumption” in international relations, which falsely assumes that religion was successfully privatized in 1648 and remains irrelevant to modern state behavior.

Hurd’s argument is structured around several core themes:

1. Two Varieties of Secularism

Hurd identifies two distinct trajectories of secularism that dominate Western political thought and international relations:

- **Laicism:** Rooted in the Jacobin and French traditions, laicism seeks to forcefully expel religion from the spheres of power and authority. It views the mixing of religion and politics as inherently irrational, dangerous, and an impediment to modernization and democratization.
- **Judeo-Christian Secularism:** Rather than expelling religion, this accommodationist tradition views the separation of church and state as a unique achievement that grew out of a shared Judeo-Christian heritage. In this view, Judeo-Christian values are the very foundation and “common ground” upon which Western secular democracy rests.

2. The Construction of the Secular West Against an “Islamic Other”

Hurd argues that these Euro-American secular traditions—and the national identities they inform—were consolidated historically through a performative opposition to Islam. In both laicism and Judeo-Christian secularism, Islam has consistently been represented as the antimodern, anti-Christian, and theocratic “Other”. By defining Islam as backward and despotic, countries like France and the United States were able to define their own national identities as inherently modern, rational, and democratic.

3. Secularism’s Impact on International Relations (Turkey and Iran)

Hurd demonstrates how these entrenched secularist mindsets dictate Western foreign policy and international interactions, using Turkey and Iran as primary examples:

- **Turkey and the EU:** European resistance to Turkey’s accession to the European Union goes beyond economics or human rights; it represents a profound cultural sticking point over secularism. Turkey’s alternative trajectory of secularism threatens both the French-style laicist insistence on privatizing religion and the Judeo-Christian secularist belief that Europe is inherently a Christian civilization.
- **The United States and Iran:** The 1979 Iranian Revolution was utterly “unthinkable” to American policymakers because it defied their fundamental secularist assumption that modernization equates to secularization. Because the revolutionaries successfully overthrew an authoritarian, US-backed secular regime (the Shah) and brought religion into the public sphere, the US viewed the revolution not just as a geopolitical threat, but as a direct affront to American national identity, which is anchored in the belief that secularization and democratization are inseparable.

4. Rethinking Political Islam and Religious Resurgence

Ultimately, Hurd argues that international relations theory fails to understand “political Islam” and the global “religious resurgence” because it relies on biased, Western secularist categories. Rather than viewing these movements simply as irrational backlashes against modernity or regressions into premodern theocracy, Hurd suggests they are active, modern contestations of how the secular and the religious are defined and divided. She urges scholars and policymakers to move

beyond the rigid “secular vs. theocratic” binary and recognize that there are multiple, legitimate ways to negotiate the boundaries between religion and politics globally.

4.3 Taylor 1998

In “Modes of Secularism,” Charles Taylor explores the historical development of secularism, explains why it is functionally necessary for modern democracies, and proposes a specific model of secularism as the only viable path forward for today’s highly diverse societies.

Here is a summary of the core themes in Taylor’s essay:

1. The Historical Roots and Two Early Strategies

Taylor notes that secularism originated in Western Christendom (from the Latin *saeculum*, meaning ordinary or profane time) and emerged as a practical solution to the horrific Wars of Religion, aiming to find a basis for peaceful coexistence. Historically, this took two different forms:

- **The Common Ground Strategy:** This approach sought to establish political order based on doctrines shared by all Christian sects, or at least all theists (such as Natural Law). However, this strategy breaks down as society diversifies to include non-believers, Muslims, and other faiths, because the “common ground” inevitably shrinks.
- **The Independent Ethic Strategy:** Thinkers like Grotius and Hobbes attempted to abstract political morality from religion entirely, basing it instead on undeniable facts of human condition, rationality, and sociability. While this aims for neutrality, Taylor points out that religious believers often perceive this “independent ethic” as a rival, partisan worldview (a form of militant unbelief), leading to cultural friction and making secularism feel like an alien imposition, especially in non-Western contexts.

2. The Democratic Imperative for Secularism

Taylor argues that secularism is not optional; it is an inescapable requirement of the modern democratic state. Modern nation-states are “imagined communities” characterized by “direct-access” horizontal relationships between equal citizens, rather than the hierarchical structures of the past. Because a democracy relies on collective self-rule, it requires a strong sense of common identity, patriotism, and commitment from its citizens. However, if this shared identity is tied to a specific religion (Taylor uses the rise of Hindu nationalism in India as a prime example), minority groups are fundamentally excluded from the “sovereign people”. This exclusion destroys democratic legitimacy and can lead to severe consequences, including forced emigration or ethnic cleansing. Therefore, secularism is functionally indispensable to bond religiously diverse citizens together in a democracy.

3. The Solution: An “Overlapping Consensus”

Because both the “common ground” and “independent ethic” models fail in highly diverse modern societies, Taylor advocates for a third approach, borrowing John Rawls’s concept of an “overlapping consensus”.

- In this model, citizens converge on a shared set of politico-ethical principles and goods (such as human rights, equality, and popular sovereignty).
- Crucially, the state does not demand that everyone share the same *underlying justification* for these principles. For instance, a Christian might support the right to life because humans are made in the image of God, an Enlightenment thinker might support it based on rational human agency, and a Buddhist might support it based on the ethics of non-violence.

By focusing on shared principles rather than demanding a universally agreed-upon philosophical or religious foundation, Taylor concludes that the overlapping consensus is the only viable form of secularism available to successfully manage

the deep diversity of the modern world.

5 Class - 6

5.1 Scott 2007

Joan Wallach Scott's *The Politics of the Veil* examines the underlying anxieties that led to the 2004 French law banning “conspicuous” religious signs in public schools, a law primarily aimed at the Muslim headscarf. Scott argues that the veil was not simply a religious garment, but became a screen onto which the French republic projected its deep-seated fears about immigration, national identity, and changing gender roles.

Here is a summary of the core arguments and themes in Scott's work:

The Timeline of the Controversies

Scott traces the *affaires des foulards* (headscarf controversies) through three key eruptions that demonstrate a progressive hardening of the French government's stance:

- **1989:** Three Muslim girls were expelled from a middle school in Creil for refusing to remove their headscarves in the name of *laïcité* (French secularism). At this time, the Council of State ruled that wearing religious signs was not incompatible with secularism, provided they did not constitute acts of provocation or proselytism, leaving room for accommodation.
- **1994:** Education Minister François Bayrou attempted to ban all “ostentatious” signs of religious affiliation, leading to the expulsion of 69 girls, though this decree was frequently overturned by the courts.
- **2003–2004:** Following intense media attention—such as the expulsion of the Lévy sisters, who had converted to Islam—and a government commission headed by Bernard Stasi, the government ultimately passed a law in 2004 definitively banning the headscarf in public schools, ending any room for mediation.

Political Motivations: Co-opting the Far Right

Scott argues that the 2004 ban was not a reaction to an objective worsening of religious extremism in schools, but rather a response to domestic political pressures. **Successive mainstream governments utilized the headscarf issue to capture the anti-immigrant vote and counter the rising popularity of Jean-Marie Le Pen's far-right National Front party.** By focusing on a few girls wearing headscarves, politicians were able to substitute a symbolic gesture for the much harder task of addressing the actual social, economic, and racial discrimination faced by North African immigrants.

The Clash with French Republican Universalism

A major driving force behind the ban was the ideology of French republicanism, which relies on **abstract individualism**. This ideology dictates that to be equal citizens, individuals must strip away their ethnic, religious, and social differences in the public sphere to achieve “sameness”. Consequently, French republicans viewed the headscarf as a dangerous symbol of *communitarisme* (communalism)—a refusal to assimilate into a singular, homogenous national culture.

Sexuality and the “Open” vs. “Covered” Gender Systems

In Chapter 5, Scott explores how the language of the ban—specifically the choice to outlaw “conspicuous” or “ostentatious” signs—revealed a hidden preoccupation with sexuality. Scott contrasts two idealized gender systems to explain the intense French reaction:

- **The French “Open” System:** In France, women's emancipation and equality are culturally equated with the visibility of the female body and sexual availability. The exposure of the body is positively valued as a hallmark of liberty.

- **The Islamic “Covered” System:** In contrast, the Islamic tradition recognizes sexuality as a disruptive force that poses risks to social and political order. Modesty and the covering of the body are used to manage these libidinal energies and prevent sexual temptation.

For French observers, the veil was not seen as a sign of modesty, but rather as something perverse and sexually abnormal. **French politicians and feminists interpreted the veil as an aggressive rejection of French gender norms and a denial of men’s “natural” prerogative to look at women’s bodies.** President Jacques Chirac even described the veil as a “kind of aggression”. Some extreme commentators compared the psychological impact of the veil to genital mutilation, arguing it completely alienated young girls from their femininity, which in the French system is conferred by male desire and visual stimulation.

The Psychology of Denial

Scott concludes that the obsessive focus on saving Muslim women from their “oppressive” culture served as a convenient distraction for France. By pointing to Islam as the ultimate source of sexism, **French feminists and politicians engaged in a “psychology of denial,” allowing them to ignore the ongoing gender inequalities, wage discrimination, and domestic violence within their own borders.** Ultimately, the headscarf ban was a way for France to assert the absolute superiority of its own civilization and naturalize its specific cultural approach to sex and equality.

5.2 Scott 2018

Based on the provided excerpts from Joan Wallach Scott’s 2018 book *Sex and Secularism*, the article challenges the popular contemporary assumption that secularism inherently guarantees gender equality. Scott argues that this association is a historically false, politically motivated invention used primarily to assert Western superiority over Islam, while distracting from ongoing gender disparities within Western societies.

Here is a summary of the core arguments:

The False History of Secularism and Gender Equality

Scott approaches secularism genealogically, viewing it not as a fixed definition but as a discourse that changes depending on its political context. She points out that when the concept of secularism emerged in the 18th and 19th centuries, the separation of church and state actually relied on **gender inequality**. Western modernity assigned women to a feminized, private sphere of family and religion, while reserving the rational, public realms of politics and economics for men. Gender equality was completely absent from the founding documents of Western democracies. It was only in the late 20th century, amidst the “clash of civilizations” rhetoric, that gender equality was retroactively claimed as a primordial value of secularism.

Christian Secularism and the “Muslim Question”

The modern discourse of secularism has deep roots in colonial history and is heavily intertwined with Christian exceptionalism. By contrasting an allegedly enlightened, sexually liberated West against a supposedly repressed, misogynistic Islamic “other,” secularism functions to justify claims of white, Western, and Christian racial superiority. Scott compares the modern stigmatization of Muslims in Europe to the 19th-century “Jewish Question,” arguing that a racialized view of Islamic culture is now used to portray Muslims as fundamentally incompatible with European democratic life.

Sexual Emancipation vs. True Equality

In the chapter titled “Sexual Emancipation,” Scott critiques the contemporary Western tendency to conflate gender equality with sexual freedom. She observes that in modern secular discourse, human agency is heavily reduced to the

fulfillment of sexual desire. Consequently, emancipation is often narrowly equated with the public exposure of the female body and the freedom to act as a consumer.

- **The “Covered” vs. “Uncovered” Binary:** Western discourse relies on a strict opposition between “covered” Muslim women, who are deemed sexually repressed and trapped in the past, and “uncovered” Western women, who are considered autonomous and liberated.
- **The Illusion of Freedom:** Scott notes that the Western “liberated” ideal often simply translates to the freedom to conform to conventional, market-driven norms of femininity that cater to male desire. She argues that pushing Muslim women to “unveil” is closely linked to capitalist demands that women participate in the market as both consumers and commodities.
- **A Distraction from Structural Inequality:** Scott stresses that historically, emancipation (the lifting of formal legal restraints) is not the same thing as substantive equality. By focusing obsessively on sexual desire and the visibility of women’s bodies as the ultimate metric of freedom, Western nations create a convenient distraction from deeply rooted structural inequalities—such as wage disparities, glass ceilings, domestic violence, and lack of social support—that continue to affect women globally.

Ultimately, Scott concludes that secularism operates as a polemical discourse that uses the language of gender equality to define national borders, perpetuate racial hierarchies, and mask the unresolved challenges of gender inequality within the West itself.

5.3 Summary of Lecture

France in the 90’s, the “laïcité” debate

1989:

- **Ernest Chénier** → Principal in a school who expelled 3 hijabi.
- Council of State (highest instance): wearing religious is okay as long it is not an “act of pressure, provocation, proselytism, or propaganda” → NOT incompatible with laïcité BUT school must decide case by case

1994:

- **Bayrou** → Minister of Education at the time
- BANS all signs of religious affiliation → they are intrinsically part of proselytize
- 69 girls expelled
- Council of state overturns it → Back to 89

2003:

- **Alma & Lila Lévy** → 2 french girls converted to Islam
- **Chirac** → French President → Ask Stasi for a commission to examine the religious signs ban
 - **March 2024:** Ban all religious signs besides small one (no more kippa, hijab, or cross)

2009:

- Nicolas Sarkozy → French President instates a commission for Muslims for their cult
- stated the burqa would not be tolerated, framing it not as a religious issue, but as an affront to women’s freedom, dignity, and a modern form of “enslavement”

Now:

- Debate motivated by the rise of populism far right (Rassemblement national/Lepen) takes that debate
- Debate is much deeper:

- Security issue
- Freedom and men's control over woman → autonomous self
- Islam and France's culture and traditions

Scott:

- Racism:
 - Rooted in the north african colonialism of france and systematic marginalization of muslim immigrants
- Secularism + Individualism:
 - "Liberté,Égalité,Fraternité" → "Freedom, Equality, Brotherhood"
 - Rooted in French identity to be free
- Larger social issues + Sexuality
 - French → openness; Islam → modesty

Behind the debate:

- Clash between sex and sexuality → France and Islam have 2 views:
 - France: Open: Woman must and can be sexualized
 - * Putting a veil is seen as a restriction on woman and man's own desire and sexuality
 - * Sexual promiscuity and freedom is seen as liberty
 - * **Psychology of denial:** We assume that even though there a sexual difference, **they can be ignored** and do not matter in a free society
 - Islam: Covered: modest and sexual *unavailable*
 - * **Psychology of recognition:** There are **differences between male and female** AND THUS we should avoid that sexuality disrupts the public space and keep it in **private sphere** rather than public

Sex and Secularism:

- Secularism = freedom + gender equality ?
 1. Gender equality **NEVER** been at the center of secularism discourse
 2. Using gender equality as an argument for secularism → Aims to prove western superiority (not factual)
 3. We are not looking at the right issue and it's just a shortcut avoiding the real difficulties
- 19th and 20th Centuries:
 1. Promiscuity vs procreation
 2. Private sphere = Feminine WHILE Public = politic = manley
 3. Women in kitchen → not just religious thing but product of discourse of secularism
 4. Wait years for woman to start have the same right (100 years after french and American revolutions) → secularism has never been about woman freedom
 5. When Islam came to western world → THEN woman rights were taken as a part of "**New**" **Secularism → Sexual liberation**
 - Women are **instrumentalized** → giving rights was not just of pure kindness but because it comforted western society in their supposed superiority over islam
 - **Sexual emancipation != gender equality**
 - It is like **liberal feminism** → Men pose as the savior but actually we just change the exploiter
 - * From being exploited by aytollah for the headscarf → exploited by pimp on onlyfans cause "that's freedom"
 - * Never a true emancipation → woman is still an object, just flashy rebranding, stays a commodity
 - Foucault: actual emancipation is de-sexualization
 - Sexuality + politics → always an unstable discourse

- How to achieve emancipation ?
 1. Definitions:
 - “Lifting of restraints imposed by superior physical force or legal obligation” (Oxford English Dictionary)
 - Patria potestas (roman law)
 - NOT ABOUT EQUALITY → about freedom
 2. Reification of desire
 - Sexuality is singled out
 - Motivate actions by desire
 - Freedom act upon and fulfill desires (no equality in gender)

6 Class - 7

6.1 Sweet 2007

William Sweet's article uses the debate between Intelligent Design (ID) and evolutionary theory to explore the broader conceptual relationship between scientific propositions and religious beliefs. He argues that a failure to understand the distinct epistemological nature of these two types of claims hinders the resolution of both the ID debate and the larger discourse on science and religion.

The Intelligent Design vs. Evolution Debate

Sweet observes that ID and naturalistic evolution are often treated as competing hypotheses. He contends that critics who dismiss ID simply as a religious belief commit the genetic fallacy; ID should be evaluated on its scientific merits and plausibility, rather than being rejected based on the religious motivations of its proponents. Conversely, he argues that ID advocates are mistaken if they believe that ID, even if scientifically successful, can definitively *prove* religious claims. For instance, a scientific conclusion that biological complexity requires an “intelligent designer” does not prove the distinctively religious belief that this designer is the Creator God worshipped by believers.

The Distinct Nature of Scientific and Religious Beliefs

To clarify how the two realms relate, Sweet contrasts the nature of their propositions:

- **Scientific propositions** describe matters of fact, are publicly testable, and are inherently neutral and objective. Their meaning and truth do not depend on the ethical, metaphysical, or religious values of the person testing or stating them.
- **Religious beliefs** are a response to the world that have expressive roles, indicate a disposition or intention to act in certain ways, and are intimately tied to specific practices, such as prayer and worship. Despite these dispositional elements, religious beliefs still possess a descriptive dimension and can be evaluated for truth based on internal consistency, tradition, and coherence with other known truths.

While distinct, Sweet notes they are not radically separate because both make claims about the same world and share core general criteria for truth.

The Mutual Interaction of Science and Religion

Sweet rejects both “fideism” (which radically separates science and religion) and “strict empiricism” (which tries to reduce religion to science). Instead, he outlines a correlative relationship where both fields must ultimately cohere:

- **How Science Bears on Religion:** Science cannot definitively prove religious beliefs; for example, archaeological proof of the crucifixion of a man named Jesus would not prove the religious belief that he is the Messiah. However,

science can *indirectly challenge* religious beliefs by disproving empirical claims those beliefs presuppose. When scientific discoveries conflict with religious assumptions, it forces believers to re-examine what their beliefs actually mean and clarify whether certain claims—like a six-day creation—are meant scientifically or religiously.

- **How Religion Bears on Science:** While religion cannot directly disprove a scientific proposition from within the bounds of science, it can serve as a guide and a judge. Religious beliefs can encourage scientists to pursue socially responsible research that respects human dignity, or they can challenge scientists when they make broad philosophical assumptions, such as insisting on purely materialistic accounts of human consciousness.

Ultimately, Sweet concludes that because both scientific practice and religious belief must be subordinate to the truth, they bear on one another and their true propositions must eventually “fit together” without one being reduced to the other.

7 Class - 8

7.1 Hansson 2017

Sven Ove Hansson’s 2017 chapter, “Theories and Methods for the Ethics of Technology,” explores the foundational concepts and methodologies used to evaluate ethical issues surrounding technology. He argues that the ethics of technology should not simply be a rigid application of traditional moral theories, but rather a flexible, practical discipline that utilizes a variety of analytical tools.

Defining Technology

Hansson notes that the meaning of “technology” has evolved significantly. In the 19th century, it primarily referred to *knowledge* about the skills and tools of craftsmen, but by the 20th century, it shifted to describe the actual tools, machines, and procedures themselves. Importantly, he emphasizes that technology encompasses not only physical hardware but also the social practices and rules associated with its use; understanding this social embedding is crucial for evaluating its ethical impact.

The Limits of “Applying” Moral Theory

Hansson strongly critiques the notion that applied ethics—including the ethics of technology—is merely the direct application of overarching moral theories (like utilitarianism or deontology) to solve practical problems. He identifies three major problems with this approach:

- **The Theory Choice Problem:** Moral philosophers fundamentally disagree on which moral theory is the “correct” one, making the choice of which theory to apply seem arbitrary.
- **The Derivation Problem:** Broad, abstract moral theories rarely provide specific, clear-cut answers to the nuanced, concrete dilemmas encountered in practical fields.
- **The Moral Novelty Problem:** Emerging technologies continually introduce unprecedented moral dilemmas (e.g., virtual reality, biotechnology, and human enhancement) that older, established moral theories could not have foreseen.

Alternative Methods for the Ethics of Technology

Because strict application of theory is insufficient, Hansson proposes alternative ways to structure ethical investigations:

- **Tempered Use of Moral Theories:** Instead of using moral theories to dictate answers, ethicists should use them to provide precise conceptual tools (like “prima facie rights” or “moral luck”) and rigorous “thought patterns” (like

utilitarianism's weighing of advantages). He also advocates for seeking a **"reflective equilibrium,"** a process of mutually adjusting specific moral judgments and general principles until they align logically.

- **Principlism:** Another alternative is to use area-specific guiding principles, similar to the four pillars of medical ethics (autonomy, non-maleficence, beneficence, and justice). However, Hansson cautions that applying principlism to technology requires extensive reworking. Unlike clinical medicine, which focuses on an individual patient, technological decisions often impact large, diverse groups with conflicting interests, meaning concepts like individual "informed consent" do not easily translate.

Impartial Analysis vs. Ethical Activism

Finally, Hansson examines the role of the ethicist, distinguishing between impartial scholarly analysis and ethical activism. He outlines four types of ethical statements and argues that an ethicist's true academic expertise lies in **analytical normative statements**—identifying hidden assumptions, separating normative issues from facts, and clarifying alternative standpoints. While ethicists are free to personally advocate for specific moral choices (activism), Hansson cautions that they should not present this advocacy as scholarly expertise, as doing so can diminish the credibility of their academic work.

7.2 Verbeek 2008

Peter-Paul Verbeek's 2008 article, "Obstetric Ultrasound and the Technological Mediation of Morality," argues that technologies are not morally neutral instruments, but active participants that shape human moral subjectivity. By integrating "postphenomenology" with Michel Foucault's ethical theories, Verbeek demonstrates that technological artifacts profoundly mediate our moral decisions.

Postphenomenology and Technological Mediation

Verbeek builds upon Don Ihde's "postphenomenological" approach, which breaks away from classical phenomenology's foundational, anti-science attempt to describe "reality itself". Instead, postphenomenology argues that human perception and reality are mutually constituted through technological mediation. Technologies do not simply connect pre-existing subjects to pre-existing objects; rather, they help construct what is real to us. Consequently, Verbeek argues that we must abandon the idea of the autonomous human "prime mover" in ethics. Moral agency and intentionality do not reside solely in humans, but are distributed across human-technology associations.

The Moral Mediation of Obstetric Ultrasound

To illustrate how technologies shape moral actions, Verbeek analyzes obstetric ultrasound. Far from being a neutral "window to the womb," ultrasound acts hermeneutically by actively translating data into a specific representation, fundamentally altering the ontological status of the unborn:

- **The Fetus as a Person:** Ultrasound visually isolates the unborn from the mother's body, makes it appear larger, and can reveal its gender, thereby constituting the fetus as a separate, individual person or "baby".
- **The Fetus as a Patient:** By translating the unborn into quantifiable medical variables and disease risks, ultrasound frames pregnancy as a medical process to be monitored.
- **Parents as Decision-Makers:** This technological mediation fundamentally changes the experience of "expecting" a child into "choosing" a child. Even if a couple did not explicitly seek to make a moral choice about abortion, the technology forcefully constitutes the parents as decision-makers responsible for assessing risks and determining the life of the unborn child.

Foucault and Moral Subjectivity

Because technology inevitably shapes who we are and what dilemmas we face, Verbeek turns to the late work of Michel Foucault. Foucault viewed ethics not merely as obedience to a set of moral imperatives, but as the active constitution of one's own subjectivity. He emphasized "practices of the self"—the explicit styling and shaping of oneself into a moral individual. Verbeek suggests that in our modern era, technology is one of the most powerful determinants of this subject constitution.

A New Ethics of Technology: Technological Ascesis

Verbeek criticizes ethical frameworks that try to separate humanity from technology, such as "precautionary" approaches that aim to pull the emergency brake on technological development. Because humanity and technology are intimately interwoven, Verbeek advocates for a practice of **technological ascesis**.

This does not mean retreating from technology; rather, it means deliberately using technology while reflecting on and actively modifying how it mediates our lives. For example, expecting parents can engage in moral self-practices by consciously choosing *how* they use ultrasound—perhaps by refusing it, using it only to determine the birth date without seeking risk assessments, or explicitly accepting all tests. Ultimately, Verbeek concludes that the ethics of technology should be centered on asking what kind of mediated subjects we want to become, and explicitly shaping our relationship with the technologies that constitute us.

8 Class - 9

8.1 Falhquist 2017

Jessica Nihlén Falhquist's 2017 chapter, "Responsibility Analysis," explores the conceptual and normative issues surrounding moral responsibility in the context of technology and engineering. The text primarily investigates whether engineers have a special moral responsibility and how the design of technology affects human responsibility.

Conditions for Moral Responsibility and Blame

Traditionally, moral responsibility is viewed as a backward-looking concept focused on blameworthiness. Falhquist outlines five standard conditions that must be met to hold an agent morally responsible for a negative outcome: **capacity, causality, knowledge, freedom, and wrongdoing**. The process of ascribing blame involves both immediate emotional reactions (such as resentment) and a detached, cognitive reflection of the situation. Ultimately, holding someone responsible serves two main aims: **fairness** (blaming someone for a wrongful act) and **efficacy** (detering people from repeating the act).

Backward-Looking vs. Forward-Looking Responsibility

A central theme in the text is the distinction between two types of responsibility:

- **Backward-looking responsibility** focuses on who caused an undesired event and who is to blame.
- **Forward-looking responsibility** focuses on who should do something to prevent the event from happening again in the future.

Falhquist illustrates this using Sweden's "Vision Zero" road safety policy, which shifted the focus from the backward-looking responsibility of individual drivers who cause accidents to the forward-looking responsibility of "system designers" (e.g., local governments and car manufacturers) to create infrastructure that prevents fatal collisions.

Individual vs. Collective Responsibility Responsibility can be shared among individuals and collective entities, such as corporations or states, which often creates tension between what is a fair distribution of responsibility and what is an

effective one. In large-scale engineering and technological development projects, it is often difficult to identify exactly who caused a negative outcome because so many agents are involved. This dilemma is known as the “**problem of many hands**”.

“Taking” Responsibility: Task vs. Virtue

In addition to distributing responsibility, Fahlquist explores the forward-looking concept of an individual actively “taking responsibility,” which is conceptualized in two ways:

- **Responsibility as a Task:** Unlike basic duties that dictate specific actions, responsibilities dictate *results*. For example, engineers are often expected to “see to it” that a safe product is achieved, requiring them to evaluate actions and formulate a plan to reach that result.
- **Responsibility as a Virtue:** This is a cultivated character trait where a person proactively takes on more responsibilities than their specific tasks dictate. In engineering, this virtue requires moral imagination and empathy to consider how technological failures might impact real people.

How Technology Affects Responsibility

Fahlquist argues that **technological design actively alters how responsibility is distributed and how willing users are to take responsibility**. Behavior-steering technologies can shift or even hamper a user’s disposition to act responsibly:

- **Alcohol Interlocks:** Devices that prevent a car from starting if the driver has consumed alcohol force sobriety but remove individual responsibility for the choice to drive sober. This might inadvertently cause users to view the device as a catch-all test for fitness to drive, leading them to ignore other risks like fatigue.
- **GPS Tracking for Children:** While parents use GPS to protect their children, over-relying on this technology signals to children that someone else is always in control. This lack of independent experience can hamper a child’s ability to develop the virtue of responsibility as they grow.

Ultimately, Fahlquist concludes that engineers hold a moral responsibility that extends beyond their basic job descriptions, and they must carefully reflect on how their designs impact the behaviors and moral development of users.

8.2 Technology and responsibility

Hans Jonas’s 1973 article, “Technology and Responsibility: Reflections on the New Tasks of Ethics,” argues that the unprecedented scale and power of modern technology have fundamentally altered the nature of human action, thereby rendering traditional ethical frameworks insufficient. He calls for a radically new ethics oriented toward the long-term survival of humanity and the preservation of the natural world.

The Limits of Traditional Ethics

Historically, human interaction with the non-human world (*techne*) was considered ethically neutral. Using the chorus from Sophocles’ *Antigone* as an example, Jonas illustrates that ancient humans viewed nature as an inexhaustible, immutable force. Because human incursions into nature were superficial and localized, traditional ethics was strictly **anthropocentric**, focusing entirely on direct interactions between humans in the “here and now”. Ethical knowledge did not require scientific expertise; it was rooted in common sense and applied to immediate consequences.

The Vulnerability of Nature

Modern technology has shattered this paradigm. The biosphere is no longer immune to human action; it is profoundly vulnerable. Because technological interventions are global, cumulative, and irreversible, nature itself has become an object of human responsibility. Jonas suggests we must move beyond anthropocentrism and consider whether the

extra-human world has a moral claim on us in its own right. Furthermore, because our actions have such sprawling, long-term effects, acquiring predictive knowledge is now a moral duty.

A New Moral Imperative

Because traditional ethics, like Kant's categorical imperative, evaluates actions based on immediate, logical consistency for the individual, it cannot account for the distant future. Jonas proposes a new imperative tailored to the age of technology: **"Act so that the effects of your action are compatible with the permanence of genuine human life"**. For the first time in history, the continued existence of humanity has become an object of moral obligation.

Technology Modifying Humanity

Jonas notes that the most ominous shift is that *homo faber* (man the maker) is now turning his technological power upon himself. He highlights three areas where technology threatens the human condition:

- **Life Extension:** Advancements in biology might allow us to significantly delay or conquer death. However, immortality would require halting procreation to prevent overpopulation, leaving a stagnant world of old age devoid of the spontaneity and fresh perspectives of youth.
- **Behavior Control:** Using chemical or electronic means (like brain implants) to pacify behavior or artificially induce happiness strips individuals of their autonomy. Bypassing the normal human ways of dealing with problems reduces people to programmed behavior systems, threatening human dignity.
- **Genetic Control:** Taking evolution into our own hands through genetic design forces us to ask whether we possess the wisdom, the standards, or the right to design future human beings.

The Need for Humility and Representation

Modern technology operates on a "utopian" scale, pushing us toward extreme goals that impact the total condition of the globe. This creates a paradox: we require supreme wisdom to manage these powers, yet the same scientific movement that gave us this technology has eroded our belief in objective truths and norms, leaving us in a state of "nihilism".

Because our power to act vastly outstrips our ability to foresee consequences, Jonas calls for a **new kind of humility** based on recognizing our ignorance. Furthermore, he notes a severe political challenge: representative governments are unsuited for this task because future generations—the ones who will suffer the consequences of our technological choices—have no lobby or political power today. Ultimately, Jonas concludes that since religion can no longer universally anchor morality, we must use reason to urgently build an ethics capable of guiding our awesome technological power before we default to a disastrous one.

9 Class - 10

9.1 Moula 2017

Payam Moula and Per Sandin's 2017 chapter, "Ethical Tools," explores the definition, application, and evaluation of practical methods designed to improve ethical deliberations, specifically within the context of technology assessment.

What are Ethical Tools?

Ethical tools are practical methods or conceptual frameworks—such as checklists, codes of conduct, or flowcharts—that help users (often non-philosophers) reach ethically informed judgments. Most ethical tools function by ensuring that users consider the right aspects in the correct sequence, focusing primarily on the **inclusion, order, and occasionally the weighing** of relevant moral considerations.

Examples of Ethical Tools in Technology Assessment

The authors outline several specific tools used to assess new technologies, which range from individual frameworks to large-scale meeting formats:

- **The Ethical Matrix:** Developed by Ben Mepham, this tool creates a grid that cross-references broad ethical principles (such as well-being, autonomy, and justice) with various stakeholders affected by a technology. While it is praised for being simple and helping users identify relevant considerations, it has been criticized for **failing to help users weigh conflicting values to actually reach a decision**. It also risks reproducing the biases of the facilitators if key stakeholders are initially left out of the matrix.
- **The Ethical Delphi:** A virtual, anonymous committee format used to elicit **expert opinions** over several rounds of written exchange. It highlights both consensus and disagreement while preventing dominant personalities from taking over, though it has been criticized for lacking public transparency.
- **The Consensus Conference:** A multi-day event focused on **public participation**, where a panel of laypeople learns about a controversial topic from experts and deliberates to reach a consensus. While valuable for democracy, it can suffer from low or self-selected attendance, and genuine consensus might be masked by minority views staying quiet.
- **Convergence Seminars:** A shorter, few-hours-long format that evaluates emerging tech using **hypothetical retrospection**. Participants are divided into groups to discuss concrete future scenarios, evaluating choices based on the idea of avoiding future regret.

Evaluating Ethical Tools

The authors note that despite the wide variety of ethical tools available, there is surprisingly little literature on how to determine what makes a tool “good”. They review several approaches:

- *Stability:* Ellen-Marie Forsberg suggested tools should have intermethodological stability (different users reaching the same conclusion). However, Moula and Sandin argue that if a tool guarantees the same result regardless of the user, it is likely biased; **a good tool should still leave room for the user’s specific values and judgment**.
- *Ethical Soundness:* Kaiser et al. proposed a binary framework where tools are either ethically “sound” or “unsound” based on factors like transparency and inclusion of values. The authors argue this is too rigid, as tools exist on a spectrum of quality.
- **Purposiveness:** Moula and Sandin propose evaluating tools based on their “purposiveness”—**how well they achieve their specifically designed aims**. Universal metrics should include comprehensiveness and user-friendliness, while context-specific metrics might include transparency (if public scrutiny is expected) or procedural fairness (for public engagement tools).

Future Challenges

The authors conclude with future challenges for ethical tools. They suggest that the rise of “ethics apps” and autonomous technological systems might alter or even diminish the traditional role of professional ethicists. Furthermore, they highlight a major limitation of most ethical tools: they generally only work if the users belong to the same **moral community**, meaning they must share a significant baseline of ethical values to deliberate effectively.

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